Data Insights Question-Type Tracker

5 Question Archetypes, Pacing Targets, Calculator Shortcuts & 4-Week Mastery Schedule

1. The 5 Data Insights Question Archetypes & Timing Targets

Master the distinct cognitive requirements and strict pacing budgets for all 20 questions in the 45-minute DI section.

DI Question Type	Format & Structure	Target Time / Question	Core Tested Skill
Data Sufficiency (DS)	1 question stem + 2 statements; determine sufficiency without computing	1m 45s – 2m 00s	Logical deduction, constraint evaluation, avoiding over-calculation
Multi-Source Reasoning (MSR)	2-3 tabbed documents (text, tables, emails) with 3 associated questions	2m 30s – 3m 00s (split across 3 Qs)	Cross-synthesizing disparate text and quantitative evidence
Table Analysis (TA)	Sortable spreadsheet table with 3 binary-choice statements (True/False)	2m 00s – 2m 15s	Column sorting logic, statistical median/mean inference, filtering
Graphics Interpretation (GI)	Scatterplots, bar graphs, bubble charts with fill-in-the-blank dropdowns	1m 30s – 1m 45s	Visual trend slope analysis, axis scale reading, outlier detection
Two-Part Analysis (TPA)	Problem prompt with a 2-column response table requiring mutually dependent choices	2m 15s – 2m 45s	Simultaneous constraints, algebraic modeling, multi-variable logic

Section Budget: 20 Questions / 45 Minutes = Average 2 minutes 15 seconds per question.

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2. On-Screen Calculator Rules & Mental Math Tactics

The on-screen calculator is available ONLY in Data Insights. Learn when to use it and when it slows you down.

Calculation Scenario	Recommended Tool	Efficiency Tip & Shortcut	Common Trap to Avoid
Multi-digit percentage change (e.g. 4,892 to 6,114)	On-Screen Calculator	Calculate difference first, then divide by initial value	Typing errors on numeric keypad; always clear memory first
Comparison of fractions (e.g. 5/17 vs 7/23)	Mental Math (Cross-Multiply)	Cross-multiply numerator and denominator (5*23 vs 7*17)	Do not waste 20 seconds punching fractions into calculator
Estimations within wide answer choices	Mental Math (Rounding)	Round to nearest 10 or 100; check options range	Calculating exact decimals when choices differ by >15%
Compound growth or sum of 8 table rows	On-Screen Calculator	Use the running sum feature; double-check sorted column	Losing track of row index when reading across columns

Best Practice: Limit calculator usage to fewer than 6 questions per DI section to preserve speed.

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3. 30-Day Data Insights Starter Roadmap

A month-long sequence to build DI proficiency from zero to 80+ scaled score.

- Week 1: Pure Data Sufficiency Mastery. Drill 40 value vs yes/no questions; memorize the 12 classic DS traps (e.g., zero, negative numbers, non-integers).
- Week 2: Graphics Interpretation & Table Analysis. Master spreadsheet sorting tactics and graphical axes reading without falling for optical illusions.
- Week 3: Multi-Source Reasoning Deep Dive. Learn the "Read Tabs First" strategy: spend 90 seconds understanding tab topics before reading questions.
- Week 4: Timed Two-Part Analysis & Full Sectional Mocks. Execute 4 full 45-minute timed DI sets and analyze pacing on your error log.